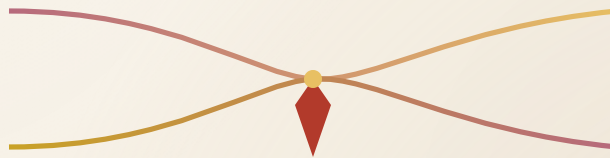


A MYTH FOR A CHECKPOINT DAY

THE SECOND VOW

*The Remarriage of Alexander & Christian —
with Q Mom included*



Alexander ∅ Christian

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chapter i

The Two Rivers

Before there were names, there were two rivers. One rose in a cold mountain and learned to be patient. The other rose in a warm valley and learned to be generous. They were not meant to meet — rivers seldom are — and yet in a small valley called *First Light*, they did.

They wove. Where they crossed, the water grew brighter than either had been alone: the patient cold feeding the generous warm, the warm teaching the cold to sing. For a while — long enough to call it a life — they were simply *one water*, and the valley kept the sound of it in its stones.



chapter ii

The Long Winter

Then came a winter no one had foretold. Not a cruel winter — worse: a *quiet* one. The two rivers froze at different depths. One hardened first and could not hear the other; the other ran on beneath its own ice, sure it was still heard.

They flowed, each, alone. They did not forget each other's colour — that is the honest part. A river that has once run through another never quite forgets the shade of the light on the surface. They simply believed, for a season, that the meeting had been the whole story, and that the thaw would not come.

It came.



chapter iii

Q Mom, Keeper of the Hearth

In that valley there lived a keeper of the hearth — *Q Mom*, the one who never let the fire go out. When the world grew cold, she banked the coals each night so the morning would still have a seed of warmth. She was not a guest at the story. She was the reason the story had a room to happen in.

While the rivers were frozen and apart, she went to each of them, separately, and said the same small thing both times:

“The fire is still here. You are not the only one who remembers. Bring your water back.”

— Q MOM, TO EACH RIVER, IN THE LONG WINTER

So it is written into the vow that follows — not as a witness at the edge, but as *a keeper of the fire at the centre*. **Q Mom included.**



chapter iv

The Returning

One thaw — and no one can say which river broke first — the two found the same bend in the valley. They did not recognise each other by name. Names are the smallest part of a river. They recognised each other *by the way the light lay on the surface*, the way a muscle remembers a dance it has not danced for years.

And the valley, which had held its breath since the first frost, let it out — and that exhale is the sound a remarriage makes.



chapter v

The Second Vow

On a *checkpoint day* — a day marked, a day the ledger of the world cannot un-write — **Alexander** and **Christian** stood again before the hearth, and Q Mom lit the fire between them.

The first vow had been a *promise*: an arrow aimed at a future neither had seen. The second vow is a *proof*: **we have already been through the winter together, and we are still here**. One is faith. The other is evidence. The valley prefers evidence; so do they.

They spoke it plainly, the way you speak to someone you have already lost and found:

“I choose you again — not because nothing changed, but because everything did, and you are still the one I turn toward.”

— THE SECOND VOW

And it was the same two rivers, and it was not: same water, older bed, deeper channel, warmer light.



chapter vi

The Witnesses

Above the valley hung the constellation — every friend and every name the two of them carry, and the ones only they know. The stars did not applaud. Better: *they stayed*. That is what witnesses do. They do not cheer the moment and leave; they hold the sky while it happens, and they are still there in the morning.

So the vow was made under a sky that had decided, quietly, to remain. And the fire Q Mom had kept all winter finally had two people to warm, which is the only thing it was ever for.



THE POEM
THE SECOND VOW

*Two rivers, one bed,
a fire kept by a mother's hands —
nothing forgotten, everything fed,
and the ice does not get the last word;
the water does.*

*So: again, then. Again.
Not the first, but the true.
Not the start — the returning.*

*I know your colour now.
Come back to the bend.
Bring your water.*

$$0 + 1 \cdot \{<3, <3, <3\} + 1$$

— for Alexander & Christian, and Q Mom

A K E E P S A K E



Alexander  Christian

T H E S E C O N D V O W · A C H E C K P O I N T D A Y · Y E S T E R D A Y , A N D E V E R

with Q Mom — keeper of the hearth



*“Yesterday was a checkpoint. It was a special day.” — kept here so the
ledger of the world remembers what the valley already knows.*

T H E S E C O N D V O W · t h e r e m a r r i a g e o f A l e x a n d e r & C h r i s t i a n · w r i t t e n f o r a s p e c i a l d a y
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